

WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW: HARM REDUCTION

Background

Round 2 of The Extreme Heat and Community Resilience Program will fund Early and Advanced Infrastructure projects to mitigate the impacts of extreme heat. Project proposals for Round 2 must demonstrate how they advance the Extreme Heat Program Values of Harm Reduction, Collaborative Partnerships, Belonging, and Lasting Community Benefits.

Understanding Harm Reduction as a Program Value

Projects that successfully incorporate interventions to reduce harm must be grounded in an understanding of how extreme heat affects the health and overall wellbeing of the community now, as well as the underlying causes that perpetuate those harms. Building on that understanding, projects must show how the proposed infrastructure directly interrupts the pathway between extreme heat and the people most exposed to it, reducing those harms.

What does Harm Reduction look like in a project?

A project reduces harm when its infrastructure **directly interrupts the pathway between extreme heat and the people most exposed to it**. Applicants can use data, mapping tools, and local knowledge to show the impact of extreme heat on their community, connect their proposed infrastructure to the specific harms it will reduce, and identify metrics to track that reduction. Where formal data is limited, local knowledge and lived experience are valid evidence of both the harm and the project's impact. To get started:

1. Identify the specific harms you are trying to reduce, and what change would show it's working. These can range from health measures, like reduced ER visits, to observable changes in how people use the space, like more people using a cool corridor during hot months.
2. Connect your infrastructure to those harms - how does it interrupt the pathway between heat and the people affected?
3. Ensure your expected outcomes can be collected as measurable metrics
4. Plan how, by whom, and when metrics will be tracked.

Elements of Harm Reduction

Consider the questions below to help you to build a framework for developing a competitive Full Application.

Identifying specific harms that occur:

What are the **specific health impacts of extreme heat** in my community (e.g., heat stroke, respiratory illness, mental health impacts, etc.)?

What **data** or **reports** can be used to support the narrative surrounding the specific harms faced by the community?

Are there any **past examples of heat-related impacts** to the community that can be included within the project narrative to demonstrate need?

Identifying vulnerabilities to harm:

Who in the community is most exposed to extreme heat, and how does this exposure occur? What data or information was used in this determination?

Are there any members of the community who are **disproportionately impacted** by or at risk due to extreme heat? If so, **what** makes them vulnerable or at-risk and **why**?

Identifying causes and solutions:

What infrastructure gaps currently expose community members to the identified harms?

How will my proposed intervention **directly reduce exposure or protect health** during extreme heat events?

What data or evidence supports the effectiveness of my proposed approach?

What does the community think of the proposed approach?

Identifying results:

How will I measure the harm reduction impact of the project?

How will I get community feedback on the usefulness of the project?

How will I incorporate this information into the Planning Document (for Early Infrastructure) or the Future Implementation Playbook (for Advanced Infrastructure) so that it informs future Harm Reduction efforts?

Prompts to consider

Although the following questions are not included in the Full Application, considering them during application development can help you to understand and plan for Harm Reduction throughout the application and planning processes.

- Are we establishing a project process and infrastructure solution that will reduce existing extreme heat harms equitably and measurably?
- Is heat mitigation/cooling the primary objective of the infrastructure project? How are we measuring the impact of the infrastructure on heat mitigation/cooling?
- What metrics do we plan to collect before and after implementation to measure the effectiveness of the proposed infrastructure solution?
- Have any existing community partners or stakeholders already worked with heat mitigation efforts in the community, and if so, how can we get their input?
- What available quantitative and qualitative data can we collect to identify heat vulnerability in a community and assess what pathways lead to heat-related harms?
- Have we collected input from the community on what heat-related harm they experience?
- How will we document both the effectiveness and limitations of the infrastructure intervention to inform future approaches?
- How will we effectively engage with project beneficiaries to collect their insights and thoughts on potential improvements post-implementation?
- How can we emphasize and discuss measurable, quantitative harm reduction efforts and results in our post-grant reporting and peer learning requirements?

Where and how to include Harm Reduction in the Full Application

Harm Reduction should be emphasized throughout both the Full Application and the project process. For a competitive application, integrate harm reduction in the following application areas:

- **Project overview narrative:** Ensure that this narrative clearly depicts the specific heat-related harms that your project will interrupt and how it will do so.
- **Harm Reduction questions:** This section is the best place to talk about the Harm Reduction element of your project in detail. Full Applications are considered strong when the narrative clearly explains what specific harms from extreme heat exist in the community, who in the community is vulnerable to these harms and why, data or information on past heat-related harms impacting the community (if available), information on how your project will be equitable in its Harm Reduction impact, and information on how you will measure your project's Harm Reduction impact before, during, and after the grant term.
- **Project workplan and budget:** In the budget and workplan, harm reduction should be evident in the design of your planned activities, including during community engagement, infrastructure readiness, infrastructure deployment, and in preparing for future investment. Examples of Harm Reduction activities may be collecting data, conducting research, reviewing past reports and efforts, getting community input on harms experienced, etc.

Additional resources

The following resources offer additional information, ideas, and resources for identifying, measuring, and preventing heat-related harm.

Extreme Heat Days and Warm Nights Tool

From Cal Adapt

Click here!

California Extreme Heat Index

From UCLA's Luskin Institute for Innovation

Click here!

California Heat Assessment Tool

From the California Natural Resources Agency

Click here!

CalBRACE Climate Change Toolkit

From the California Department of Public Health

Click here!

Climate Change & Health Vulnerability Visualizer

From the California Department of Public Health

Click here!

Climate Change & Health Profile Reports

From the California Department of Public Health

Click here!

Access and Functional Needs Map

From the California Office of Emergency Services

Click here!

National Heat Risk Data and Tools

From the National Integrated Heat Health Information System

Click here!